

Past Meets Future 2026 submission

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Format: C - System and Prototypes

Description:

As part of an effort to bring new visitor engagement tools to GLAM institutions, the following prototype has been developed: **an interactive conversational AI tour guide**. This AI guide uses a controlled knowledge base, retrieving grounded information through RAG (Retrieval Augmented Generation).

The current format is simple. Visitors are given headsets with boom mics. They connect them to their phones, and access the AI guide online. The phone shouldn't be used throughout the tour; the AI voice interaction through the headset makes up the whole experience. Visitors are guided through an exhibition, are asked questions along the way, and are in turn welcomed to ask questions themselves. A future goal is to move away from BYOD to create a dedicated lightweight device, in an effort to reduce visitor friction at museums.

The main challenge with AI voice models is their default to act as "assistants", as that's how they're trained. This guide is built differently, using special code constructs which allows for long-format sessions where the guide stays proactive, and not collapsing back to its default "assistant" personality.

Links:

1. Website: www.kushyaguide.com
2. Recent exhibition tested with the public (LinkedIn post with images):
https://www.linkedin.com/posts/davidvonhuth_hello-all-its-been-a-while-since-i-posted-ugcPost-7487574596070617089-QMIY/?utm_source=share&utm_medium=member_desktop&rcm=ACoAABK2TrgBVBNF7_rzOFU-0L9JqcNdZrMpLbo
3. Audio recording from example interaction with AI guide:
<https://drive.google.com/file/d/18wQm2d0uE90cdgNmiW67K4tLzLvoH0c5/view?usp=sharing>